

Usability Testing: Study Sync

Introduction

The key takeaways of this usability testing focus on two key areas: the ease with which users navigated the sign-in and account creation process, and the effectiveness of the group chat and group creation features. By observing two testers interacting with the application, we identified specific points of confusion or friction in the user experience. The feedback and suggestions gathered are vital for guiding necessary adjustments and improvements before the app's final version is launched.

Tasks

- Task 1: “You want to open a new account and explore study groups that align with your preferences. Once you create your account, you type in the incorrect password on the sign in page.”
- Task 2: “You want to gather nearby students for the upcoming midterms. You also want to notify the groups you are on about the upcoming midterms”

Persona 1

- Persona 1: Yandré Caban, 18, Freshman at UPRM
 - **Background:** Yandré is a Freshman student at UPRM with upcoming midterms. Yandré doesn't know many people who are taking Computer Science, but prefers to study in groups rather than alone.
 - **Goals:** Set up a studying session with fellow students who are also searching for study groups.
 - **Frustrations:** There are no formal ways to bring awareness to study groups forming near students.

Notes

- User 1, Task 1:
 - Confused when picking a year of study. The user suggested that we include year number instead of academic rank.
 - Confusion towards the “What do you want help with?” question at the last step of account creation.

- The navigation bar seemed confusing to navigate through. The user had trouble determining where to click.
- User 1, Task 2:
 - When opening group chat, the user assumed they had to click the big group card, rather than the group chat button below.
 - Trouble finding the button to exit the group chat page.

Feedback

- User 1 General Feedback
 - For the most part, navigating the app was simple and straight forward. If a freshman were to use it, they would not have a hard time. Only had trouble navigating through the navigation bar.
 - On step 4 of creating an account, the second question seemed redundant, since the user was already asked for their field of study. The navigation bar was confusing, since there was no clear division between the buttons before pressing them.
 - Remove the “Tell others what you like” section in the final step of account creation and remove the specialization question from step 4. Include an option to send verification code for password reset via phone number. Include the option to apply colors to study group cards. Incorporate more colors, since the app looks bland and uninviting.

Persona 2

- Persona 2: Pragya, 22, Senior at Fisk University
 - **Background:** Pratistha is a senior at Fisk University. She is an incoming Full-time Software Engineer at Amazon. She likes to study with her friends, both online and in person at the library. She hosts study sessions often.
 - **Goals:** Create a study group, keep friends updated through the group chat, and share resources.
 - **Frustrations:** Information flow is too scattered. Meetings are on Zoom, chats are on WhatsApp, and resources are shared via Google Drive links.

Notes

- User 2, Task 1:
 - Pointed out design inconsistency on the onboarding pages. Some pages have a percentage to mark completion, while others have colored boxes.

- Curious how a user could start over onboarding after reaching the last page; pointed out the last page had no back or cancel button.
- User 2, Task 2:
 - Suggested an upload photo button on the create group chat page.
 - Questioned about the sidebar on the create group chat page.
 - Confused about adding members to the group, asked where the button was. Also, the invite link to the group was missing.
 - Pointed out the missing button (to leave the group).

Feedback

- User 2 General Feedback
 - The user was quite satisfied with the user experience in general. They mentioned an intuitive and pretty standard UI/UX design. For the group chat page, they mentioned adding a few buttons to simplify all possible user actions.
 - The onboarding could be simpler by asking only for the necessary user information at first, then showing curated pop-ups about study group preferences after signing up. Suggested to dedicate a separate page for that too, so that it's easier for the user to edit information and preference.
 - For design consistency with the group chat page, add an upload picture option in the create group page because the group chat has a group photo icon. Also, instead of the cancel button at the end of the page, a red cross button at the top would be more intuitive.

Key Issues and Proposed Solutions

Issue 1: Confusing Navigation and Unclear User Flow

Users experienced difficulty navigating the application, particularly with the navigation bar and key action points. There was confusion about where to click (e.g., group cards vs. chat buttons), how to exit pages, and how to access essential actions like leaving a group or restarting onboarding.

Hypothesis:

This likely occurs because interactive elements (buttons, cards, navigation items) are not clearly differentiated, and the navigation layout lacks clear visual hierarchy and guidance. Not all pages follow the same design pattern for buttons and icons.

Evidence

“I thought I had to click the big group card instead of the chat button.”

“The navigation bar was confusing. I didn’t know where to click.”

“I couldn’t find how to exit the group chat page.”

Proposed Solution:

Redesign the navigation system to improve clarity and usability. This includes:

- Introducing clearer visual hierarchy and spacing between navigation items
- Using consistent and recognizable icons alongside labels
- Adding clearly visible action buttons (e.g., “Leave Group,” “Back,” “Exit Chat”)
- Making interactive elements (such as buttons vs. cards) more distinguishable through size, color, and affordances

Issue 2: Inefficient and Confusing Onboarding Process

Users found the account creation process confusing and repetitive. The onboarding process was also inconsistent, with different progress indicators, and it was difficult to navigate since there were no clear “back” or “cancel” options.

Hypothesis:

This likely occurs because the onboarding flow includes redundant questions, unclear wording, and inconsistent design patterns, which increase cognitive load and make the process harder to follow.

Evidence:

“I didn’t understand what ‘What do you want help with?’ meant.”

“This question feels redundant.”

“There’s no way to go back or restart from here.”

Proposed Solution:

Streamline and standardize the onboarding experience by:

- Removing redundant or unclear questions and focusing only on essential information
- Using a single, consistent progress indicator throughout onboarding
- Adding navigation controls such as “Back” and “Cancel” on all steps

- Moving preference-based questions (e.g., study interests) to a separate, editable section after account creation

Issue 3: Missing or Incomplete Features in Group Functionality

Users encountered friction when interacting with group-related features, including difficulty finding options to add members, missing invite links, lack of a “leave group” button, and absence of customization features (e.g., uploading group photos or adding colors to group cards).

Hypothesis:

This likely occurs because key group management features are either missing or not included as part of a complete, end-to-end group creation and interaction flow.

Evidence:

“Where do I add members?”

“I couldn’t find a button to leave the group.”

“Is there a way to invite people to this group?”

Proposed Solution:

Enhance group functionality by introducing and standardizing key features:

- Add clearly labeled buttons for “Add Members,” “Invite via Link,” and “Leave Group”
- Include an option to upload group photos during group creation
- Ensure consistency between group creation and group chat interfaces
- Introduce customization options such as color-coded group cards to improve visual engagement and organization.